

Chapter 48: Sisters

Why would her own name appear in the underworld? And carved on a Red Spider Lily? In an instant, countless questions flooded her mind. Ning Fuyi couldn't help but feel a chill down her spine. She bent down to touch that withered flower stem, and a faint stinging sensation lingered at her fingertips.

A trembling sense of connection began from her fingertips, causing sharp pain in her brain.

If this wasn't her, why would she feel this way? But if it was her...

Hadn't she been reborn after Chu Qingqiu slayed her with a sword in her previous life? How could she have had time to cross the Bridge of Helplessness? But if she had become a Red Spider Lily before being reborn, where were her memories of crossing the Bridge of Helplessness?

Moreover, after time was reversed, everything from the original timeline should have disappeared. Why would a flower stem remain, still following the original pattern?

A thousand years wasn't long or short - enough to forget many things. Ning Fuyi couldn't remember many later events very clearly, but not remembering clearly was different from not being able to remember at all.

Ning Fuyi suddenly felt a kind of fear - not of someone else, but of herself.

What had she forgotten?

"There are more and more of them." Chu Qingqiu's voice suddenly rang in her ear. Ning Fuyi seemed to awaken, looking up in bewilderment to see that more ghosts had surrounded the area, encircling the flower grove so tightly it was impenetrable. Looking around, it was like purgatory.

Just when they were at their wit's end, a red skull suddenly fell from mid-air. Black smoke scattered everywhere, and the bronze door to the underworld opened again. The originally sinister crimson door frame now seemed like salvation.

"Let's go quickly." Chu Qingqiu said urgently. Ning Fuyi didn't hesitate either, lightly touching her toes and leaping into that patch of black smoke.

Suddenly strong winds arose, and Chu Qingqiu's body left her back. Ning Fuyi felt the emptiness and instinctively reached back to touch her, but was grabbed by the woman's hand instead. Many bloody arms intercepted them from all sides, and finally, with a low shout, they were all shattered to powder by the white bone.

Then her back hit something, and the pain made Ning Fuyi's vision go black. When she brushed off the grass and dirt from her head and got up, Chu Qingqiu descended gracefully like a deity, her white robes fluttering.

She stood before her with divine clarity and noble bearing.

People really were different from each other. Ning Fuyi got up covered in dust and dirt, flinging her scattered black hair behind her, but suddenly felt something soft under her feet. Looking down, she was greatly alarmed and quickly dodged to the side.

What she had stepped on was a bright red tongue, flat and long, severed at the root.

"This is..." Ning Fuyi crouched down, picking up a branch to lift the tongue. "So familiar - it looks like that judge's."

The judge had probably thrown out that skull before dying, bringing them out of the underworld to this place.

"Ghost officers are beings of yin and yang¹. Even when dead, they leave corpses. Where is his body?" Ning Fuyi carefully put down the tongue and got up to search. However, after circling the entire area, she didn't see half a dead ghost.

"The corpse shouldn't be here." Though Chu Qingqiu still showed no expression, she was actually puzzled too. She closed her eyes and used divine consciousness to survey the surroundings, seeing barren mountains all around. The nearest one was like a sharp axe thrust into the ground, looking menacing even in broad daylight.

"There seems to be a mountain village a hundred li ahead, but the sky above is full of miasma, making it difficult for divine consciousness to see clearly." Chu Qingqiu opened her eyes and spoke, gripping the white bone in her hand tightly, sensing something amiss.

Meanwhile, Ning Fuyi, who was still searching diligently nearby, now ran back with a partially broken copper bell, handing it to Chu Qingqiu: "Look at this."

The bell had an ancient design and felt heavy in hand. Both inside and outside were carved with totems symbolizing the underworld - an object exclusive to underworld ghost officers left behind by that judge. As soon as it touched Chu Qingqiu's hand, it began ringing *ding ling ling*.

"When the copper bell rings, there must be grievances²." Chu Qingqiu's eyes were profound. "The judge brought us here before dying. Besides completing his duty, perhaps he wanted to ask us for help."

"This should be underworld business. We don't even know what happened here, so how can we help him?" Ning Fuyi glanced at the copper bell. "The underworld must have other ghost officers. Why should we wade into these muddy waters?"

Chu Qingqiu looked at her, her pupils showing a glassy luster in the sunlight. She said lightly: "Having the heart but lacking the strength is far better than having strength but lacking compassion. If I cultivate only for self-preservation and not for all living beings, what use is cultivation?"

"Ordinary ghosts and monsters can't harm a judge. There must be great evil here. I'll lend you Bai Lin³. You should return to the sect first." Chu Qingqiu said, waving her sleeve. Bai Lin, whose injuries had healed, appeared refreshed and leaped toward Ning Fuyi with its paws raised.

After speaking, Chu Qingqiu took the bell and walked forward. Ning Fuyi reached out to pet Bai Lin, leading it as she turned around.

"You work for all living beings, but I only care about self-preservation." Ning Fuyi flung her hair behind her, but after walking only a few steps, she looked down to see Bai Lin's night-pearl-like eyes staring at her pitifully. For no reason, she sighed and cursed under her breath.

"Divine Venerable, wait for me!" she shouted, changing direction.

Half an incense stick's time later, she was walking alongside Chu Qingqiu on the rugged mountain path. Tall mountains flanked both sides with apes crying intermittently. There was no other road, so they didn't need to spend effort finding one.

At this time, the sky had darkened with the quiet appearance before a storm. Black clouds pressed heavily overhead, as if one could reach up and pluck off a piece.

"Who knows what evil this place holds." As Ning Fuyi spoke, she slowed her pace, seeing a person standing by a manure cart at the bend ahead, repeatedly wiping mud off an ox.

"Good, there's someone. Let's ask." She walked forward and bent down, saying, "Excuse me..."

But as soon as she spoke, that person suddenly raised his head. When their eyes met, Ning Fuyi's scalp nearly flew off.

That wasn't a human face at all - the entire facial skin was undulating up and down, as if countless worms were hidden beneath the skin. It made one feel itchy all over. During the writhing, a dead white maggot fell from his eye with a *splat*.

Ning Fuyi quickly stepped back two paces, hearing the man speak hoarsely: "Ah?"

"What..." Seeing something was wrong, Chu Qingqiu behind her was about to step forward, but Ning Fuyi quickly raised her hand to stop her.

Chu Qingqiu was afraid of ghosts, so she probably wouldn't want to see this thing that was more terrifying than ghosts either. So she said it was nothing and continued asking with a stiff upper lip: "We're passing through this area. May I ask what place this is? Is there somewhere ahead where travelers can rest?"

The man continued speaking in his hoarse voice, making inarticulate sounds twice before finally uttering a complete phrase: "Axe... Head... Village."

After speaking, he stiffly raised his hand, pointing toward an even darker path.

Ning Fuyi noticed that his palms were the same as his face, with maggots writhing under the skin. She looked away, thanked him, and returned to Chu Qingqiu's side.

While pulling her along, she described what she had seen and heard.

"I knew it was strange, but not this strange." Chu Qingqiu frowned. She looked back at that person, who still stood under the dark clouds, mechanically wiping the ox's back.

"Could you see if he had any ghostly aura?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

"I could see clearly - he's human." Ning Fuyi answered. "That's exactly what makes it so eerie - he's still alive."

However, the path that person pointed out wasn't false. After walking another li, a village faintly appeared at the foot of the mountain. The village wasn't small, with delicate houses scattered along both sides of the valley. Such scenery should have been beautiful, but the thick clouds overhead that never dispersed added much gloom to this place.

"After we go down, don't reveal our identities. Just pretend to be ordinary people." Chu Qingqiu instructed, then transformed her appearance. Her brocade robes changed to plain clothes, and all her hair ornaments and accessories were removed, simply wrapped with a cloth band.

However, plain clothing only made her features appear more elegant and otherworldly. Ning Fuyi looked away and shook out her own clothes.

There wasn't much room for change - she already looked quite ordinary like this. So she simply let down the hair on both sides, covering some of the sharpness in her brows and eyes.

The two pretended to be travelers coming down the mountain. When approaching the village, they passed by a large temple from which came heavy incense smoke. Who would have thought that in such a remote wilderness, there would be such flourishing incense worship.

Moreover, the temple wasn't run-down - it even looked somewhat new. The brick walls and red paint seemed newly built, standing out brilliantly red against the green grass and yellow earth.

"What statues are worshipped here? I've never seen them before." Ning Fuyi peered inside and exclaimed. Behind the incense altar stood dozens of clay statues, each with distorted features and eyes looking down at the ground, making one's blood run cold.

"Worshipping so many ugly god statues at once - what is this temple praying for? Are the people in this village so greedy?" Ning Fuyi leaned against the door frame counting, but suddenly felt a cold palm slap the back of her head, making her stagger into the temple.

She rubbed the back of her head and turned around, seeing Chu Qingqiu standing coldly outside the door, saying: "One must not be disrespectful."

"To tell the truth, don't you think they look bizarre?" Ning Fuyi muttered.

"Indeed." Chu Qingqiu spoke, then turned her back and continued into the village, causing Ning Fuyi's lips to curve upward uncontrollably.

She looked back once more at those god statues before striding to catch up.

As soon as they entered the village, she felt everything was eerie. The entire village was too quiet - quiet like a graveyard. Most people were huddled in their houses, and only occasionally could one see a few people carrying hoes, walking by like dark shadows.

Everyone who passed by them stared straight at them without blinking, and even after walking far away, they would turn back to look.

A stream flowed through the middle of the village. Several elderly women sat by the stream, beating clothes in their hands with *crack crack* sounds. When they saw the two newcomers, they all stopped what they were doing.

"Their stares are like they want to devour us. Could this be a cannibal village?" Ning Fuyi stood on tiptoe and whispered in Chu Qingqiu's ear.

Her breath blew against Chu Qingqiu's earlobe, and Chu Qingqiu imperceptibly moved her feet to increase the distance between them.

"If it were a cannibal village, that wouldn't be so frightening." Chu Qingqiu shook her head.

Some noisy children ran over from the side, shouting something. Only when they got closer could the words be made out as a nursery rhyme:

One broken hand, one broken waist, count to three and hang up high. Four plays with mud, five eats grass, the sixth one laughs in a cage. Seven bugs, eight legs, nine mouths croaking away...

"These lyrics are too creepy." Ning Fuyi pressed her lips together. Just as she was about to say something to Chu Qingqiu, one of the women by the stream suddenly stood up and loudly scolded those children.

The children quickly scattered with screams when they saw this. The woman cursed a few words in a shrill voice, then walked toward them with a smile, looking kindly: "Where are you two from? What brings you through our village?"

She spoke with a heavy accent, but it was still comprehensible. This person seemed normal, so Ning Fuyi forced a smile and replied: "We're passing through and looking for a place to stay the night. But why is the village so quiet in broad daylight?"

"It's a long story." The woman's face was dark, with only her teeth gleaming white. "If you young ladies don't mind, you can rest at my home. My house is over there."

She pointed toward the depths of the village. Her hands had skin like tree bark - clearly from years of hard labor.

"Are you two sisters? You look unmarried and quite pretty, especially this one..." The woman moved closer to Chu Qingqiu, reaching out to touch her face. A heavy smell of wood ash hit them.

Seeing Chu Qingqiu's displeasure, Ning Fuyi quickly stepped between them, positioning herself in front of the woman.

"She's my aunt."

Ning Fuyi smiled as she spoke!

Footnotes:

¹ **Beings of yin and yang (阴阳人):** In Chinese mythology, ghost officers exist between the realms of the living and dead, having both spiritual and physical aspects

² **When the copper bell rings, there must be grievances (铜铃一响，必有怨事):** A saying indicating that supernatural bells only ring when there are unresolved injustices or spiritual disturbances

³ **Bai Lin (白麟):** Chu Qingqiu's white qilin (Chinese unicorn), a divine beast companion